

Music

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Grade boundaries

Higher level overall

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 10	11 - 21	22 - 38	39 - 52	53 - 66	67 - 80	81 - 100

Standard level overall

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 10	11 - 20	21 - 38	39 - 51	52 - 64	65 - 77	78 - 100

Exploring music in context

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 2	3 - 4	5 - 8	9 - 11	12 - 14	15 - 17	18 - 24

Experimenting with music

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 2	3 - 4	5 - 10	11 - 14	15 - 17	18 - 21	22 - 28

Higher level the contemporary music maker

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 3	4 - 7	8 - 12	13 - 17	18 - 22	23 - 27	28 - 32

Presenting music

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 5	6 - 10	11 - 16	17 - 21	22 - 27	28 - 32	33 - 38

Exploring music in context

The range and suitability of the work submitted

The selection of musical material has a significant impact on the overall quality of student submissions. Frequently, students choose pieces based on personal preference (not to be confused with “personal context”), rather than selecting works with a clear potential for meaningful analysis.

Often students struggled to adequately identify and justify/explain the area of inquiry (AOI) and context of the pieces they selected. In some cases, students limited their exploration to only two pieces, neglecting the benefit of engaging with multiple contexts/AOI/cultures (breadth and diversity). Conversely, others chose an excessive number of pieces, resulting in a shallow analysis that lacked the depth required for each individual piece.

While a few submissions were well-conceived and demonstrated strong analytical capabilities, most students fundamentally misunderstood the requirements, leading to work that lacked meaningful exploration. In these cases, the pieces were only briefly mentioned rather than explored in depth, which greatly impacted the overall quality of the submissions. Furthermore, many students included pieces that met the requirements of C1 and C2 but which had not been adequately researched. This lack of depth was evident in the corresponding marks for these criteria, which reflected insufficient exploration/analysis with the selected pieces.

To improve future submissions, students should be encouraged to select pieces carefully, that not only align with the requirements of the criteria but also allow for thorough and focused analysis. Teachers should emphasize the importance of understanding the component requirements in detail and guide students in selecting works that will facilitate meaningful exploration within the given context.

Student performance against each criterion

Criterion A

Many portfolios included a diverse range of musical material, though common issues were noted throughout the submissions. A frequent issue in terms of evidence was the lack of in-text citations. Another issue was the use (or lack of use) of reliable resources. Unfortunately, a significant number of students seemed to depend on unreliable websites—likely the first they found. This approach compromises the reliability of the research and diminishes the academic integrity of explorations.

While nearly all students covered at least two areas of inquiry (AOI) and listed contexts, they often did not provide adequate justification for their choices, especially regarding the contexts. In other cases, the selected pieces did not align well with these AOIs and contexts. AOI3 continues to cause confusion, with many students misinterpreting it as music solely for entertainment purposes, without recognizing its ties to drama or choreographed movement. In other cases, students declared that a piece is AOI3 because it is found in a film. While this is often the case, this is not true of music that was not originally composed as film music but used in films, such as pieces by Mozart or other composers utilized in film.

At times, the content and timing of audio uploads were inconsistent with the details listed on the cover sheet. Students often presented the timings of the original sources instead of the timings of upload 3, which is the only resource available to the examiner.

In terms of evidence, many students attached scores or screenshots, but some of these examples lacked clefs, tempi, meters, etc. These elements are required to assess them and to evaluate the argument that they support.

Criterion B1

The main issue in this criterion was quite probably the lack of purposeful analysis. Many students developed a descriptive analysis of the musical elements that were immediately evident, even when these were not relevant to the piece or style. Students often proceeded without establishing a connection of the elements explored and the purpose of them in relation to the AOI. Extra-musical findings tended to be somewhat irrelevant and anecdotal, while musical findings were often superficial. The primary issue was that the musical findings were frequently descriptive and basic, such as noting the tempo or the presence of certain note values, without deeper analysis of how musical elements were used in the pieces.

As stated before, timestamps often related to the original recording rather than upload 3 and therefore did not help support the arguments. In other cases, claims were made without supporting evidence. Musical terminology varied significantly, ranging from incorrect or rudimentary to a few excellent cases.

A number of students focused on fundamental musical elements like key, tempo, meter and instrumentation but did not delve deeply into how these features were used in the music. Although musical terminology was generally correct, it was often used superficially rather than being integrated into a thorough analysis. Furthermore, the organization of the findings was inconsistent in many submissions, with missing bar numbers in quoted examples and a lack of standardized referencing, which weakened the clarity and coherence of the overall discussion.

Criterion B2

A key concept of this component is that the exploration in section 1 should inform the artistic decisions taken in the practical exercises in sections 2 and 3. At times students selected stimuli for sections 2 and 3 that had not been explored in section 1. In other cases, students disregarded the explanation of purposeful implications that might have otherwise existed.

Criterion C1

Overall, the creating exercises were more successful than the performed adaptation exercises, particularly those that incorporated music technology and contemporary popular styles. However, some of the creations relied upon broad musical elements like meter, key, or instrumentation, which were not sufficiently distinctive or representative of the chosen stimulus. These elements lacked the uniqueness needed to clearly reflect the characteristics of the selected musical genre or theme.

Criterion C2

This criterion remains a very significant challenge for many students, unfortunately revealing a common misunderstanding of its requirements. The majority of students struggled to grasp fully the concept of performance practices

Many students approached the task as a simple transcription, while others attempted to reimagine the original piece in a different style, such as arranging a Flamenco piece in a Jazz style. However, successful adaptation requires not only an understanding of the performance practices specific to a particular style but also the ability to incorporate those practices into the student's chosen instrument. For example, violins are often played with a bow in an arco style; woodwind instruments can include tongued technique etc. This deeper level of understanding was often lacking in many submissions.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future students

Criterion A

The pieces selected for exploration should not only showcase diversity but also fit into at least two distinct areas of inquiry (AOIs). It is important for students to justify why their chosen pieces align with these AOIs and contexts. Furthermore, effective analysis requires the use of in-text citations and musical evidence to substantiate the points being made. These elements are vital in ensuring a well-rounded and academically rigorous exploration.

To improve the quality of their exploration, in selecting their pieces students should aim to select at least one piece where they can clearly identify creating conventions and another where they can clearly identify performance practices. Selecting pieces with vague stylistic characteristics or elusive performance practices might not be conducive to success. Arguments need to be supported by notated or audio evidence. Additionally, since this is an academic paper it needs to follow referencing conventions.

Criterion B1

The musical analysis requires the depth expected on an academic paper. The analysis should not be descriptive and limited to exploring elements that are not relevant. The non-musical information also needs to have depth. Students simply stating the dates of composer or their education are possibly missing relevant information about the style or aspects that link to the AOI.

Criterion B2

The overall concept of this component is that students explore pieces, extract information, and put that into practical exercises. Once this concept is understood, students should keep it in mind when selecting music to explore that will eventually be used for the creation and the adaptation.

Criterion C1

It is important for students to understand that not every musical element found in a piece qualifies as a 'convention'. For example, if a folk song is in 3/4 time, this does not mean that all folk songs are in 3/4 time; it is simply a characteristic of that particular piece. Similarly, if a popular song is in G major, this does not mean that all popular music is in the key of G major. These elements—such as meter or key—are basic musical features, but they do not represent the conventions that define a style or genre.

Conventions, in contrast, refer to the established and characteristic practices that are consistently used within a particular style or tradition of music. For instance, in a particular style of folk music there may be certain rhythmic patterns, melodic shapes, or instrumental techniques that consistently appear across multiple pieces, forming part of the style's conventions. Therefore, students should distinguish between these general musical elements and those that specifically define the conventions of a genre or tradition.

Criterion C2

It is crucial for students to fully understand the concept of performance practices, especially in the context of the adaptation exercise. Performance practices refer to the specific ways in which music is performed within a particular style, genre, or time period. This includes aspects such as articulation, ornamentation, phrasing, dynamics, tempo, and instrumentation, all of which vary depending upon the musical tradition or style. For instance, classical performance practices may involve the use of rubato or specific bowing techniques, while jazz performance practices might well include improvisation or swing rhythm.

The key to the adaptation exercise is not just reproducing the notes of a piece, but adapting them according to the performance practices that are characteristic of a particular style. This means understanding how musicians from that style approach the music, how they interpret the written notation, and how they use their instruments in ways that align with the conventions of the style.

Further comments

Understanding the requirements outlined in the Music Guide is crucial for guiding students effectively. Teachers should ensure that they are thoroughly familiar with this document as it provides the necessary framework and expectations for this music component. A significant number of students who did not perform well in this area did so not because of insufficient musical skills, but rather due to uncertainty about what was expected of them. Familiarity with the guide will help both students and teachers avoid misunderstandings and ensure that students are addressing the correct aspects of the assignment.

Experimenting with music

The range and suitability of the work submitted

It is evident that schools are starting to get a clearer understanding of this component.

Conventional creating work is still at times being submitted instead of experimental work, with the experiment being along the lines of “Can I write a sonata?”, for example. This is, however, becoming less frequent. Additionally, there were fewer instances of students presenting three completely unrelated excerpts as their creating experiments. In most cases there was some connection holding the narrative together.

Experimentation work in performance is still a challenge for schools, where it can be confused with creation experimentation, music learning experience or technical development. This resulted in work that was sometimes unsuitable for the assessment.

Performing experiments sometimes failed to give sufficient attention to the source material, making general comments about techniques in performance without pointing to where this impacted the music.

Experiments in performing encountered more difficulties in achieving full marks, sometimes due to projects that weren’t exactly experimenting: the learning process for a new piece of music, or learning a new technique, or how to use a new accessory.

The requirement to include areas of inquiry and contexts was generally observed in this session, although there remain ambiguities as to whether the AOI is referring to the stimulus music or to the method of work, (a Bach Sonata reworked on a DAW might be AOI2 or 4 for example). Most students made some attempt to justify their choices of AOI and context, with only a small minority entirely omitting identification of AOI and/or context. The requirement not to use personal context was generally understood.

Student performance against each criterion

Criteria A/C

Rationale writing was generally suitable and mostly in the middle mark band. There were more instances of students providing some justification for their choice of source material for their experimentation process. Lower scoring rationales generally had few or no references, with some students submitting self-referenced projects. It was quite common for the primary source to be named but not referenced in any way. Some students limited themselves to general background statements regarding a stimulus or genre for their rationale, without this having any bearing on the experimenting process. Higher scorers set out a project with justification for choice of source material, identification of secondary stimuli, and application of relevant research.

A good number of submissions demonstrated rudimentary music literacy, inaccuracy or incoherence in reference to musical aspects.

In commentaries, students working with technology often gave good detail on the technological process but gave only outlines when mentioning musical elements, opting for vague phrases such as “I added some chords”.

Evaluation of the experiments was often not included, or when it was present was often subjective. Students giving some analytical reflection were still a minority.

Students were better able to explain the experimentation process and their musical decision-making in cases where the series of experiments was progressive or linear.

In general, performing rationales were shorter than the creating ones.

Criterion B

Audio evidence of practical creating work continues to show a range of quality from rudimentary to excellent.

The evaluation of “development of musical ideas” (criteria B and D) was problematic when those ideas were not coming from a stimulus (source material) but created by the student themselves. These students were effectively limiting themselves to “recreating”, although stronger students managed to personalize the generic elements.

Criterion D

Audio evidence of experimenting in performing again showed a wide variety in quality, taking into account also that students were ranging from accomplished players to those who had been playing their instruments possibly for less than two years.

Stronger students showed an openness to try things out, using the various parameters available to them – sometimes going to extended, or unusual techniques. Weaker students performed with little or no discernible variation from the original.

A minority of students chose to concentrate on interpretation for the development of source material. That is, there was no attempt to adapt to another genre but merely to work with the score and to experiment with musical elements such as dynamics, and rubato. Some of these managed to obtain high marks by referring to great interpreters and then experimenting with their interpretations.

The most common and probably most effective approach for students who are not players with a number of years’ experience on their instruments, seems to be to play the same piece in different styles. This inevitably leads to some variation of the actual notes (changing a bass line, or the rhythm in an accompaniment). There remains the problem for the examiner of deciding how much of a performing experiment is actually creating.

There were a number of performing projects which involved a live instrument with a loop station. These often failed to present the audio as a performance with its build up in stages, but rather as a completed multi-track creation.

The element of improvisation sometimes helped a student personalize their rendering of a piece. Improvisation was, in fact, used almost exclusively in performing experiments rather than as a creating activity.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future students

Teachers should try to be more explicit about the differences between experimenting as a creator and experimenting as a performer.

Creating is about compositional technique, analysis of musical elements and descriptions of approaches to melody, harmony, texture, and structure, while performing is about interpretation of the stimuli, physicality of the instrument/voice, and detailed descriptions of technical and physical challenges

(weight, hand position, vocal anatomy, bowing technique and choices of mallets/drumsticks are all examples of relevant things that can be discussed).

Teachers should emphasize the distinctions between arranging and performing to better prepare students for the expectations of the assessments.

Uploaded work should be free of teachers' comments.

When working with audio technology, students should remember to refer also to the musical elements.

With research, students should try to show what it is they are taking from the research to be applied in the experimentation process.

The definitions in the Guide for the "contexts" should be read with some care. E.g. local music can include music that "may be unfamiliar to the student", but this does not mean that all unfamiliar music is "local".

Students should remember to offer some evaluation after each experimenting excerpt, and this may even be a negative evaluation if the student feels the experiment has not produced a useful result.

Higher level the contemporary music maker

The range and suitability of the work submitted

The November 2024 session continued to showcase the growing development and diversity of submissions for the Contemporary Music Maker component.

Several students demonstrated a strong understanding of the Music Guide and effectively aligned their projects with the curriculum. There were some excellent examples of students meeting the assessment criteria, supported by detailed evidence of their creative and research processes.

Conversely, weaker submissions often lacked depth and cohesion, reflecting a less robust understanding of the curriculum as a whole. Many projects leaned on non-musical aspects, and discussions were frequently superficial, failing to fully explore the stated aims or musical intentions.

Planning the project remained the strongest aspect across submissions, but many students struggled to showcase their technical proficiency and leadership in their identified roles. Compositions in particular often showed limited control and development of material, which is a notable concern at HL.

A recurring issue was the underutilization of supporting documents. Instead of expanding on their presentations, many students merely submitted transcriptions or summaries. However, a few strong examples included well-documented scores, providing a clearer view of the student's work.

Collaboration was generally understood as an essential element of the component, but its demonstration and documentation were inconsistent. Additionally, some students misunderstood the requirement for a singular 'role', referring instead to multiple roles such as "singer and composer", which is not aligned with the Music Guide.

Student performance against each criterion

Criterion A

Evidence for this criterion was heavily weighted towards planning and was often presented via PowerPoint slides with voiceovers. Some students achieved full marks by incorporating a variety of musical and research evidence, such as score excerpts, videos of rehearsals, and annotated materials.

However, many students failed to provide substantial proof of collaboration, often merely narrating their process without presenting concrete evidence.

Criterion B

This criterion remained the most challenging for students.

While a few students fully addressed the required aspects—discussing challenges and successes, examining areas for development, and evaluating musical and collaborative choices—these examples were rare.

Most students devoted too much time to planning in their presentations, leaving insufficient room to explore their creative and collaborative processes in depth. The concepts of "discusses", "examines", and "evaluates" were only sporadically addressed, leading to reliance on a best-fit approach during assessment.

Criterion C

Students who adhered to submission requirements performed well in this criterion. However, issues arose when clarifying individual contributions in collaborative projects. For example, some students presented shared responsibilities without specifying their own roles, making it difficult to assess their technical proficiency. Other submissions focused on non-musical tasks, such as concert organization, without demonstrating a clear musical contribution.

Film scores and compositions for art exhibitions were common, but many lacked strong score editing and demonstrated limited technical proficiency.

Criterion D

Most students submitted purposeful presentations, but there is still room for improvement in delivery, especially in creating engaging and varied presentations.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future students

Encourage students to thoroughly review both the syllabus and the internal assessment requirements for the CMM component, particularly focusing on Criterion B.

Emphasize the importance of clearly identifying the student's contributions, whether through annotated visuals, videos, or other means.

Ensure that students submit original material when working on arrangements and include the source material to allow for a proper assessment of their arrangement skills.

Clarify expectations for collaboration, ensuring leadership and individual contributions are clearly documented in line with the Music Guide.

Promote the effective use of supporting documents to complement presentations and provide more detailed evidence.

Further comments

Students should be reminded to state their role as singular, in alignment with the project, and demonstrate leadership within that role.

There are still many examples of arrangements without original material to check the student's actual work.

Teachers must ensure that submissions adhere to all requirements, including the 15-minute limit, the presentation of a final product, and the exclusion of adult collaborators.

Some submissions require greater emphasis on understanding the curriculum holistically and connecting project elements cohesively.

Presenting music

The range and suitability of the work submitted

This session showed a wide range of suitable work and many compelling performances and creating works showing understanding of the curriculum and competence in the carrying out of the skills acquired in the course were submitted. There were very few submissions that strayed from the expectations and demands of the requirements in Presenting in both performing and creating.

Student performance against each criterion

Criterion A

The majority of students provided a justification for the link of the AOI to the selection but quite often the link was superficial and did not dig deeply into the actual meaning or reason behind the composition composed or performed. Some students used up part of their word count of 600 words by describing lengthy personal accounts or describing the personal, local or global context when it was not necessary. Scores and bibliographies with citations were for the most part included in the programme notes.

Criterion B

The acoustic compositions showed a stronger understanding of instrumental techniques and score writing than in previous sessions. Some scores lacked adequate information for the performers which could have been clarified with a simple notational chart with short definitions of the terms used. The score writing for acoustic played MTech loop compositions was well done with adequate instructions as where to repeat the passages first played and recorded. In the MTech compositions using a DAW there were still some students using loops made by other musicians, and in the music guide it is clearly stated that the student must be the creator of the loops. Recording short quotes from other musical works (not used as loops) must be cited in the bibliography. Almost all submissions had scores for both acoustic and MTech compositions (screenshots) and most of the MTech scores were annotated in order to explain the effects used. There were fewer compositions relying heavily on repetition this session and most had reasonable development of motifs and ideas initially stated. Occasionally some of the 'musique concrète' compositions needed more manipulation of the sounds recorded and some MTech compositions needed further extension and use of the effects available.

Criterion C

The overall level was higher than in previous sessions with some excellent solo performances of a variety of genres. The ensemble recordings were of better quality and for the most part the students were either audible within the ensemble because of microphone placement, or adequate extracts were given. Unfortunately, there were still some submissions without extracts and in which the student was not audible in the ensemble recordings. Technical aspects such as intonation and tone colour were not always ideal, but there was more care taken in this area than in previous sessions.

Criterion D

In the submissions where the links to the AOIs were clearly explained, the musical communication of the roles were also clear. There was expressive playing in most of the submissions. The audio quality was generally reasonable to good quality.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future students

Most of the programme note submissions were within and close to the word count limit of 600 words. One problematic area was when students added score references in the body of the writing of the programme notes with lengthy extra descriptions of those scores. This added considerably to the word count and should be avoided or done with awareness of the overall amplification of the word count that this gives. Scores for performing are not a requirement and should not be put in the programme notes as they are irrelevant.

In the area of piano performances, it is highly recommended that the piano is tuned before the student performs and records, and that an acoustic piano is used rather than electric where possible as the tone colour is affected. Students should be aware that tone colour and pedalling are a part of technique on the piano, just as intonation is part of technique in vocal, string, woodwind, and brass playing.

Further comments

Teachers are advised to have students work on the Presenting repertoire early in the course and to discuss the roles of the repertoire so that there are no last-minute choices in the selections submitted. This will help avoid having weak linking to the AOIs and give the students a better chance in developing a wider range of repertoire.